

Money and mental health are tied up in a chicken-and-egg situation. People with severe mental illness are more susceptible to job loss, debt, homelessness, and money mismanagement. And those problems can also lead to poor mental health and keep you from getting treatment. (“It me,” as the kids say.)

The Money and Mental Health Policy Institute, which (unsurprisingly) explores the connection between money and mental health, says people in bad financial situations are twice as likely to develop major depression.

“We can work when we’re depressed; it just doesn’t feel good,” Fast said, adding that she purposefully taught herself to work through her ups and her downs. “The secret I learned and that I teach everybody is if you wait for motivation to show up when you’re depressed, it’s never going to show up. If you wait to feel good about what you’re doing when you’re depressed, it will never happen. But if you just put one foot forward and you put yourself out there and you do the work while you’re in pain, while you think you can’t work, would you believe that you cannot tell the difference between the work you do when you’re depressed and what you do when you’re stable? Depression doesn’t affect our ability to work; it affects our ability to *believe* we can work. It’s a really big difference.”

Sometimes during bouts of depression, I can’t stand up because of the physical pain in my chest and back. I have also struggled with changing meds and adjusting to new dosages that led to days of nausea and the inability to gather my hazy thoughts. How could I work under those conditions? But, like Fast, I had to, so I just did. I still have these blue periods with days of painful sobbing. I still overspend on manic impulse buys and have to constantly stop myself from getting a puppy on a whim. But I’m aware of it, and I am being treated for it with medication and lots of therapy.

The comedian Sara Schaefer, who speaks openly about her mental health in her stand-up, told me in a 2016 episode of my podcast that she had \$65,000 of credit card debt because she used money as a way to regulate her depression. “I would get depressed, and I would shop alone. I still like shopping alone. I don’t like people being there, because I don’t like judgment,” she said. When you’re depressed and you feel like you can’t control anything, making a purchase is something you can control.